Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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Simply, the oldest craft in the world



It's **basket-making**,
brought to this column
today from the oldest
inhabited continent, **Africa.**
It's a craft that predates
pottery and stone carving,
the earliest evidence of
which dates
to 8000 BCE and was
discovered in the late 19th
CE in the rift valley caves
of eastern Kenya.

In fact, it is thought that the craft could have been even older. Basket materials are biodegradable, so earlier unrecorded remains may well have turned to dust. Which makes a striking point about the sustainability of this craft, created with materials grown by the earth, finally to return to the earth.



'Sunshine' wave basket, Ghana



Rice basket,
Northern Mozambique

In this cyclical way, a renewable tradition of innumerable richly decorative forms of baskets endures on this continent. They are made mostly by African tribal women, their ancestral skills undiminished, living closely as they do with nature.



Virunga basket,
Uganda



Lidded basket,
Burundi

A widespread choice of employment, basket-making elevates the status of these women in rural areas and strengthens their voice within their social environments. Many organized cooperatives, workshops and institutions help these gifted groups successfully make and market their products.



Beaded wire baskets,
Kenya

To them, every variety of local reed, hemp, grass, papyrus, palm leaf and fibre, to mention only the commonest materials, is inspiration; stripped, boiled, smoothened, twisted or woven, plain or dyed, by themselves or intricately coiled over frames made of bark, stem or root.

The finished product could be designed for a myriad uses; for storage of foodgrain, food itself, for groceries, for clothing, as a backpack, sometimes even to carry babies, or water (yes, in baskets with impermeable weaves.)



Double-walled woven flasks for liquids, Rwanda



Zulu Illala palm basket



Telephone-wire basket with cover, South Africa

Shown above are a very few examples of the rich, vibrant patterns and imaginative basketry designs selected from this vast and extraordinary land.

And to think they called it the ‘dark continent’.

Links for further browsing

https://www.google.com/search?q=traditional%20african%20baskets&tbm=isch&hl=en-bf&client=safari&prmd=sivn&sa=X&ved=0CBQQtI8BKABqFwoTCNC49p3xl4EDFQAAAAAdAAAAABAF&biw=390&bih=745&dpr=3

https://www.slideshare.net/UJUONLINE/all-about-african-baskets-uses-and-history-59693471